

r/aiwars

Has AI Impacted The Environment? (Comment below on the impact you believe in)

Posted by u/Proof_Assignment_53 • 0 points • 26 comments

Wanting to see where this subreddit sits with AI. With it having Pro, Anti and Neutral support for AI in the same subreddit. This poll is to compare people's views on AI and the environmental impact it may have or not have caused. If you believe or don't believe it has. State the reason below.

NOTE: I'm working on building a graph that shows how this subreddit is currently divided. I'll be posting more like 20 polls now gathering information on how people view or use AI. Then creating visual statistics graph showing how this subreddit is broken down. I'm wanting to break it down for every possible point of view. Then using that to see how people truly view AI from the biggest points to the smallest points of view.

[View Poll](<https://www.reddit.com/poll/1rzdb27>)

Comments

u/Human_certified • 1 points • 2026-03-21 11:42 UTC

I don't think it's been a net positive yet, and AI consumes power and resources (data centers, servers, GPUs, power generation infrastructure mostly).

But the numbers are just *tiny* compared to other human uses, they don't even show up in an Excel pie chart unless you ask it to add thick borders.

If you want to make any kind of positive environmental impact, you should focus on pretty much any other human activity and your efforts will be 100x more beneficial to the world.

The only reason to hate on AI for environmental reasons is because you already hate AI and think this might make it go away (it won't).

u/Xdivine • 1 points • 2026-03-21 05:25 UTC

Not a fan of this question given it's something that would require people to do a lot of research in order to give an informed answer.

u/SpiritNo6626 • 1 points • 2026-03-21 03:59 UTC

Has 'AI' impacted the environment? I feel like that's kind of like saying "has C++ impacted the environment"

As always, billionaires are ruining the environment and one tool they are using as an excuse to do this right now is AI.

u/Superseaslug • 3 points • 2026-03-21 03:51 UTC

To the 6 idiots who said unrecoverable, fucking source?

u/TyoPepe • 1 points • 2026-03-21 13:55 UTC

Climate change is unrecoverable damage in the human timescale. Not specific about AI at all, but if we reverse climate change, neither me nor my sons nor grandchildren nor great-grandchildren will get to see it.

u/Ok-Breadfruit3490 • 3 points • 2026-03-21 07:40 UTC

same with the 21 morons who said none, having the datacenters just existing is *some* environmental impact

u/Superseaslug • 3 points • 2026-03-21 08:01 UTC

Agreed. Just tired of people exaggerating it

u/Ok-Breadfruit3490 • 1 points • 2026-03-21 08:07 UTC

we can recover, it will be slow but we could recover

u/PrometheanPolymath • 2 points • 2026-03-21 03:24 UTC

AI itself, or the data centers running some models? I question whether running a local model AI is any more harmful than rendering a 3D animation, or compiling an edited video, or source code for a game, or using an online API. If you are focusing specifically on public models, I've still yet to see reliable data that isn't cherry picked, predicted, separates training and generation, up to date models over years old measurements... it's all over the place, so even if it's true, it's difficult to verify.

u/YoureCorrectUProle • 1 points • 2026-03-21 02:38 UTC

I think there's a bit of a mismatch between questions and answers. Impact and damage are related but aren't exactly the same thing. Even things we'd typically consider a net positive for the environment, say solar panels, have a negative impact initially due to the resources they take to build. That doesn't mean it'd be fair to say solar panels damage the environment.

With that said there's basically only two indefensible positions here:

* None. It uses power, of course it'll have some level of impact. Even if the energy comes from renewable sources we still need to build out to match power requirements. Pretending otherwise is cope. Run Stable Diffusion generations 24/7 and you'll see a bump in your power bill similar to if you were spending way too much time gaming.

* Major. This usually comes from those who think that every data center in the world is solely built for AI and think "the cloud" is something that magically exists on wireless waves, or that generating a single image uses a gallon of water. Basically, extremely misinformed people. If we're worried about water use can we destroy the aberration that is the American lawn?

u/Proof_Assignment_53 • 1 points • 2026-03-21 02:58 UTC

I really wish I could have made the question and answers more detailed. But I'm stuck with having to make them short. Hard to fit a detailed poll on here.

u/SweetZestyclose6610 • 1 points • 2026-03-21 01:49 UTC

alright, who genuinely thinks that it has absolutely no impact? Just you drinking a bottle of water has impact even if it is incredibly small

u/HTPSI • 2 points • 2026-03-21 01:26 UTC

We use more power just to run the screens and devices in our homes than the data centers use to process the information those devices display.

You can also use an AI assistant for a year and still use less water than a single toilet flush.

Food for thought!

u/Whilpin • 7 points • 2026-03-21 01:17 UTC

It's certainly not without impact. the footprint alone is a negative environmental impact.

However it is ****way**** overblown - often to the point of hyperbole (and people think that hyperbole is legitimate)

u/Kaillens • 1 points • 2026-03-21 07:40 UTC

Totally.

AI increased (in data center and server/chip production) consumption of water. This is real and huge.

However, let's put it in today society.

Golf course use more water. Pool across the world use more water. Steak production, Jean production : This is also huge water consumer.

And daily toilet flush : that's heavy in water use overall.

Saying AI impact on water is the ecological nightmare... Is just false.

I don't see people asking to close golf course or public pool because of the ecological danger .

u/TyoPepe • 0 points • 2026-03-21 13:49 UTC

It's just about what people can/want to live without. A genie comes out of a flowerpot and will grant you a wish in exchange for erasing one of this things from the world: flushing the toilet or Will Smith munching on spaghetti. What is your pick?

Add to it that many anti-AI are already against it for other reasons, and to them the water consumption is just salt on the wound.

Also, dunno about pools, but people complain about golf courses all the time where I'm from.

u/Kaillens • 1 points • 2026-03-21 14:05 UTC

I don't disagree with this.

There is a genuine argument that could be : The water consumption for

AI is to big for what it does.

Now, this is a larger debate. That, don't make sense in our current world.

Because, this argument need first and foremost a societal change.
Fundamentaly, It's not even about AI.

It's about where are the limit we put in consumption when it come down to environment.

And this change is way larger. And the first one would be about deforestation and destruction of the ecosystem, about meat waste (approximatively 33% of the food is wasted), a lot of production, etc.

u/Kittywitty13 • 2 points • 2026-03-21 04:32 UTC

I totally agree, I lean more towards anti, but I think people way over exaggerate how much water and power Ai uses. Ai definitely uses water and power, and it does have some environmental impact, but the recourses it uses aren't causing significant damages (especially when compared to other industries)

u/Whilpin • 2 points • 2026-03-21 04:37 UTC

yep. Like the water use from corn alone is nearly 1000x more than GPT in the same timeframe - and we dont even eat 95% of it - a huge majority of it goes to feeding livestock and burning it away in our fuel as ethanol.

Theres ****way**** more effective ways to save water than telling end users to stop making silly pictures.

u/TyoPepe • 0 points • 2026-03-21 13:41 UTC

Like stop eating food? That'll save a huge amount of water indeed, but...

u/Silly-Pressure4959 • 1 points • 2026-03-21 00:59 UTC

Pretty biased questions for this one, but I personally suspect AI is net helping the environment. It's incredibly efficient compared to humans doing most tasks, so I'd only expect the positive impacts to grow as human roles are phased out. Almost anything related to datacenters (which are what AI is usually synonymous with in this type of question) are some of the most efficient ways humans use energy, full stop.

u/jellyspreader • 1 points • 2026-03-21 01:17 UTC

I've been wondering this for awhile too. As the tech grows and improves it'll only become efficient, including it's energy use.

I'm personally leaning towards AI being the key to solving the climate crisis. Understandably, not much faith left in just humans and manual methods alone.

u/Silly-Pressure4959 • 6 points • 2026-03-21 01:23 UTC

Yeah, pretty decent article on the efficiency here
[<https://blog.andymasley.com/p/computing-is-efficient>]
(<https://blog.andymasley.com/p/computing-is-efficient>). If you also factor in that the dirtiest part of all this is the power/energy source, and we already can do that in an environmentally neutral way, it kind of stands to reason at least to me in the long run it will turn out to be a net benefit no matter what.

u/PlsStopBannningMe • 1 points • 2026-03-21 00:56 UTC

water is the only real threat

u/lord_of_the_twinks • 1 points • 2026-03-21 00:48 UTC

Even though I want to say major I'm gonna say good. The issue is they the environment is being royally fucked and everything messing it up is so inter weaved